

Perceived Stress Factors of International School Students in Korea: A Grounded Theory Approach

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Abstract

Korean students attending international school are faced with unique school and academic environments, which often subject them to various stressors such as academic pressure, English-intense classes, student demographic characteristics, and Western-based school culture and learning systems. This study aims to investigate common stress factors among 500 high school students attending international schools in Korea. Employing the qualitative research method of grounded theory, iterative and inductive data collection and analysis have been conducted. Open, axial and selective coding have led to emergent themes, constructing data-based theory that constituted seven main sources of stress. Stressors were significantly associated with depressive and anxiety symptoms regarding upcoming college application and the multi-tasking nature of managing academics and activities, academic stress mainly stemming from required English writing skills, cultural adjustment on various levels, relational stress based on interpersonal interactions with peers, teachers and parents. It is deemed essential to uncover the multi-faceted needs of international school students and complement the dearth of research on Korean international schools.

Keywords: stress, stressors, international school, grounded theory, qualitative research

1. Introduction

Elements that can incur stress in students' school life often comprise academic stress, relational tension with teachers and schoolmates and family conflict. Studies have shown that adolescents with the highest level of stress are often socially inhibited and prone to extreme tension in the face of social and academic difficulties (Cimolic & Jobes, 1990). When factoring in the 'international school' context, the dynamics that students can experience in terms of stress become ever more complex. Many students around the world attend international schools so as to enrich their school life and enhance access to high-quality higher education and global career opportunities. The initial purpose of the establishment of international schools was to meet the needs of students whose parents work outside their country of origin. Many international schools share the mission of enhancing global understanding and expanded identity and promoting multiculturalism and peace (Hayden, 2006; De Mejia, 2004; Carder, 2003; Baker, 2001). They thus share consistency in terms of curriculum so that international school students at any country can have a relatively similar academic experience (Hayden, 2006).

Korea faces a unique environment in that 'international' schools form a new category vis-à-

vis 'foreign' schools. Foreign schools in Korea carry the traditional definition of international schools, whereas the term 'international school' is confined to schools that provide education based on the standard international curricula including the International Baccalaureate (IB) and Advanced Placement (AP) for students with Korean nationality that are not legally qualified to attend foreign schools. Such international schools with a variety of student population are spread across the country, with the Jeju Global Education City (JGEC) being a focal point with a concentration of 4 major international schools – namely, St. Johnsbury Academy (SJA), the Korea International School Jeju (KIS), North London Collegiate School Jeju (NLCS), Branksome Hall Asia (BHA). JGEC was created as part of an urban development initiative focused on education, featuring a variety of globally acknowledged schools. This project was launched by the government of South Korea under former President Roh Moo-Hyun to decrease the number of students going abroad for studies and to keep financial resources within the country. Essentially, JGEC represents a government-directed urban development project in Jeju centered around English education. Gaining admission to such schools is rigorous and competitive with most schools requiring passage of entrance exams that evaluate various academic and linguistic capabilities of student candidates.

Stress is viewed as a negative emotional, cognitive, behavioral and physiological process that occurs as a person tries to adjust to or deal with stressors (Bernstein, et al 2008). Stressors are defined as circumstances that disrupt, or threaten to disrupt, individuals' daily functioning and cause people to make adjustments. Stress constitutes an unpleasant state of emotional and physiological arousal that individuals experience in situations that they perceive as dangerous or threatening to their well-being (Auerbach & Grambling 1998). Stress is perceived as events or situations that cause individuals to feel tension, pressure, or negative emotions including anxiety and anger. It includes responses to existing situations that lead to physiological, emotional and behavioral changes. Whereas it is generally recognized that moderate stress motivates and fuels creativity, intense stress hinders individuals from performing difficult tasks and adjusting to new environments.

To date, there has been little academic inquiry into the stressors of international school students in Korea. These students in their adolescence and attending international schools in their home country alongside Korean classmates under a global curriculum conducted in English often undergo identity crises stress on various levels. The current study thus aims to investigate stress factors of high students attending international schools in JGEC to understand the complexities of their school life and ultimately reinforce constructive coping

strategies for stress.

2. Theoretical Underpinnings

2.1 Qualitative Research

Research is defined as a systematic and organized process of investigating an object or subject. Academic research is primarily categorized into two types: qualitative and quantitative. Qualitative research emphasizes interpreting, contextualizing, and reflecting on phenomena, whereas the aim of quantitative research is to generalize findings (Glesne, 2006). While quantitative research tests and seeks to prove hypotheses, qualitative research avoids fixed experimental setups and instead focuses on natural settings, with the researcher acting as a careful interpreter of meaning (Eisner, 1991).

Qualitative research is a methodology that enables in-depth exploration of phenomena by paying close attention to behaviors and subtle details. It is characterized by flexibility, adaptability, and deep interpretative analysis (Lim, 2024). In contrast, quantitative research views social reality as distinct from the individuals who experience it (Rossman & Rallis, 2003). Conversely, qualitative research aims to uncover the underlying meanings of experiences by exploring participants' subjective perspectives and interpretations. Unlike the objective, numerical focus of quantitative methods, qualitative research collects non-numerical data such as observations and spoken interactions. The objectives of quantification and generalization are not aligned with qualitative research's primary focus on understanding why and how certain behaviors and conditions happen.

Qualitative data collection involves methods like case studies, interviews, and observational interactions. It adopts a naturalistic approach, observing and interpreting phenomena in their genuine environments (Denzin & Lincoln, 2005). The philosophical foundations of qualitative research include constructivism, phenomenology, and hermeneutics. Constructivism suggests that knowledge arises from people's active construction of meaning based on their experiences and interactions. Phenomenology focuses on individuals' subjective awareness and consciousness, aiming to understand the world from their personal perspectives. Hermeneutics considers cultural and historical contexts in analyzing narratives and texts, often through qualitative data such as interview transcripts. This approach is especially useful in disciplines that seek to interpret human actions and beliefs.

Since qualitative research involves human interaction, it is a collaborative process between the researcher and the participants, shaped by social, cultural, and historical factors

(Atkinson, 2015). Researchers are situated within this multicultural context and approach their questions through specific epistemological lenses and methodologies (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011). Data collection typically involves interviews and observations, prioritizing rich, descriptive information over objectivity (Giacomini, 2010). The process demands systematic rigor, reflection, and strict criteria. Once data is gathered, researchers analyze it to identify recurring themes and patterns related to the research questions, all while remaining aware of their potential biases. As long as these biases are not prejudiced, subjective insights are valued for their depth and interpretive richness. Reflexivity and self-awareness about one's own identity are considered integral to the process (Muhammad et al., 2014). Ultimately, qualitative researchers aim to explore the "5W1H" (who, what, where, when, why, and how) of their subject matter and present their findings clearly and persuasively.

2.2 Grounded Theory

The qualitative research methodology known as "grounded theory" was developed by sociologist Anselm Strauss (Strauss, 1987). It is defined as a theory derived from data systematically collected and analyzed during the research process (Strauss & Corbin, 1990). Grounded theory focuses on data collection and analysis, with the aim of constructing a theory rooted in the data (Glaser & Strauss, 1967). Glaser (1992) highlighted that grounded theory employs an inductive approach rather than a deductive one. Additionally, Punch (1998) described grounded theory as not being a theory per se, but a method and strategy for generating theory from data. "Grounded" signifies that the theory arises from data, and "theory" indicates that the objective is to generate theory through data collection and analysis. Charmaz (2014) added that grounded theory emphasizes inductive strategies starting with abstract concepts to explain and comprehend data.

Grounded theory has evolved since its inception by Strauss in 1967, undergoing modifications over decades. The version by Strauss and Corbin remains more renowned and serves as a robust tool for teaching grounded theory globally (Charmaz, 2014). Charmaz (2003) summarized the history and debates around grounded theory, noting divergent directions by Glaser and Strauss & Corbin. Glaser's approach aligns with traditional positivism, while Strauss & Corbin moved towards post-positivism, emphasizing unbiased data collection, procedural verification, and acknowledging respondent views and artistic elements in analysis. Constructivist grounded theory, shaped by Strauss (1987) and Strauss & Corbin (1998), transitioned towards a constructivist paradigm, moving away from positivism. Charmaz (2006) further discussed the components of grounded theory, including

simultaneous data collection and analysis, constructing codes and categories from data, using constant comparative methods, advancing theory during data collection and analysis, memo-writing, theory-driven sampling, and conducting literature reviews post-analysis.

Anells(1996) explained that theories are interpretations from specific perspectives, acknowledging their fallibility yet evaluating their soundness and usefulness. Charmaz (2003) clearly differentiated between the real and the true in a constructivist grounded theory, which recognizes human realities and constructs images of reality based on perspectives, without seeking an absolute truth. Grounded theory aims primarily to develop new theories. Consequently, studies using grounded theory can focus on research phenomena or objects that lack a well-established theoretical basis. This might be because no theory exists for the phenomena being examined, or existing theories are inadequate—they may omit key concepts, fail to clearly define relationships among concepts, or lack validation for the specific population or context. Since grounded theory originates from the social sciences, its main epistemological focus is on predicting and explaining social behavior. Accordingly, Strauss and Corbin (1990) emphasize that grounded theory research is oriented toward understanding actions and processes.

3. Research Procedure

3.1 Research question and participant

The core research question guiding this study was: what are the perceived stressors that Korean international school high schoolers experience in their school life? The research participants for this study were selected on based on purposive sampling. A total of 500 high school students of both genders ranging from grade 9 to 12 attending international schools in the Jeju Global Education City took part in a survey conducted through the Survey Monkey tool and responded to questions that comprised short-answer and essay questions.

3.2 Data collection and analysis

As the study involves personal narration, a qualitative data collection method based on grounded theory was employed. The semi-structured survey consisted of a majority of open-ended questions that were raised to the research participants to explore their thoughts in-depth regarding stressors and what they perceived to be significant causes and contexts contributing to feelings of stress. Collected data also included a research consent form. Based on collected responses to the survey, we conducted content analysis to identify

emerging themes and patterns. The aim of grounded theory is to identify participants' main concern and develop a theory that explains their behavior. To this end, we followed the key stages of grounded theory data analysis based on open coding, axial coding and selective coding. Open Coding involves dissecting the data and assigning preliminary codes to segments. In Axial Coding, these codes are organized into categories, and the connections between them are examined. Selective Coding then focuses on identifying a central theme or core concept, around which the other categories are integrated to build a complete theory. This entire process is driven by constant comparison and theoretical sampling, where additional data is gathered to refine the theory until no new insights emerge, indicating theoretical saturation. We repeatedly read and coded participants' narratives, comprehensively analyzed data by organizing constructed meaning into categories, placing thought units, and cluster themes.

To ensure validity and reliability of the study, we exerted much effort in conducting a research that is both ethical and adheres to the principles of qualitative research and grounded theory. From inception to data analysis, we maintained close contact with the participants to ensure reliability. Also, the analyses and findings were double checked with participants to leave no room for error or misrepresentation, and the participants' feedback were taken to account.

4. Findings

Open, axial and selective coding have led to emergent themes, constructing data-based theory that constituted seven main sources of stress: 1) academic, 2) relational in school context, 3) lack of support from school, 4) self-concept and identity, 5) adolescent culture, 6) multi-tasking lifestyle, 7) pressure from family. Detailed components of each theme can be found in Table 1.

[Table 1. Thematic Data Coding Results]

Main Theme	Elements
Academic	• Self-critical perfectionism • Hard-landing transition from Korean to international school • Stress from exams' frequency and difficulty level • Anxiety over grades and overall GPA • Dissatisfaction with feedback and grades from teachers • SAT scores remain stagnant • Habit of procrastinating

	• Daily physical exhaustion and sleep deprivation • Heavy assignment load and tight deadlines • Hard to concentrate for long hours • Perceived shortage in English writing skills • Difficulty comprehending exam questions • Consuming too much time on YouTube and Internet disturbs academics • Difficulty in taking meticulous notes during class • Subjects are not interesting • Too many subjects in daily school schedule • Lack of academic guidance by parents • My parents don't read/speak English well • Loneliness and monotony in school routine • Private tutoring sessions add to the pressure • Depressive and anxiety symptoms regarding upcoming college application • Excessive private tutoring • News on changing policies worries me • AP subjects drive me crazy • I regret entering an IB school • British school system is overly complicated • Sleep deprivation and insomnia • By back and muscles hurt from bad posture
Relational in School Context	• Peer pressure • Comparative socio-economic status with peers • Teachers' impartiality towards students • Counsellors don't seem genuinely interested in me • Peers engaging in disturbing behavior in and outside of school • Smoking, drinking and sexual intercourse by peers • Cutthroat competition gets in the way of friendships • My best friend left me to join a new group of friends • I am in a love triangle • Friends keep spying on my performance • Constant gossiping • The really rich kids act ugly • My girlfriend/boyfriend is unfaithful and emotionally abusive

	• Kids keep sucking up to teachers • The incident of student suicide in my school traumatized me
Lack of Support from School	• College admissions support is weak • Counsellors are not professional enough • Teacher incompetence • Pressure from teachers to join their tutorials • Meak support and guidance from teachers • Non-active yet mandatory clubs • Dispersed and ineffective online systems • Principal's words are mere rhetoric • School clubs are not enough to support extracurricular portfolio • School doesn't provide sufficient social service opportunities • Why can't school be good enough to replace private consulting companies? • Teachers are rotating and replaced all the time • An objective centralized grading scale seems non-existent
Self-Concept and Identity	• My family is not affluent enough to provide private and professional consulting for me • My looks are not good enough • I hate my skin and pimples • I am no athletic but school requires me to be one • I am A-lingual in this school • I am losing my mother tongue • Nobody wants to date me • I seem to be the outcast in school • My passive self undermines my self-esteem • I am gender-confused • I feel neither Korean nor international • Island life collides with social instincts • I am too fat • I am too short • I am too thin • Limited time for recreation and self-discovery • As dorm student, I am sort of orphaned • My parents divorced but I hide it • It's just a bunch of Korean kids in what's called an international school • Western teachers' approaches and values don't really seep • Foreign teachers need to respect and understand Korea more

Adolescent Culture	• Gender imbalance in student population: male domination • , You gotta date to be cool • Social butterflies are everywhere • Competition to date new female student among male students • Acculturative difficulties as a fresher • They apply Korean and Western standards at once • Subtle yet ongoing bullying • The young semi-gangster group • Don't force bad habits on me • Kids reject you if you are not good in school • Groups of friends are pre-formed and hard to join • There are too many serial daters
Multi-tasking Lifestyle	• I am required to be jack of all trades • Constant juggling of academics and extracurriculars • I am required to engage in too many activities that don't interest me • School work requires too many sets of opposing skills • I am having to split my time in minutes to multi-task • My brain is distracted and not catered to multi-tasking • Input information from people and AI are multi-layered and conflicting • There are too many required club hours • There are too many athletic events during semesters • I seriously worry about my health
Pressure from Family	• Parental pressure to get good grades • Mom emphasizing her giving up on her life to support me • Sibling's academic status creates conflict for me • Excessive demand for domestic work by parents • Parents are too strict • Parents expect me to be perfect on every front • My mom is literally stalking me • Relational stress with family members • Losing studies hours looking after younger siblings • Financial constraints • My family lives apart because of my education • I feel guilty about high tuition • My parents think Ivy League is a piece of cake

	• My parents think awards and research papers serve best for college • My parents really don't know me
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5. Discussion and Conclusion

Stress is a psychological concept often defined as a sense of unease or vague fear that isn't directly tied to a specific object. Many students instinctively feel that stress hampers their ability to learn, and it has become one of the most extensively studied topics in psychology and education. Stress can be classified into three main types: trait stress, state stress, and situation-specific stress. Trait stress refers to a consistent personality trait—a long-term tendency to experience stress. In contrast, state stress is a temporary feeling of anxiety triggered by a particular event, like an upcoming test. Situation-specific stress arises from particular contexts or settings, such as attending an international school in Korea where most students are Korean nationals.

Participants in the current study experienced all three types of the above-mentioned stress in their school life. They primarily experienced stress from high academic expectations and heavy workloads. Most reported feeling overwhelmed by school assignments and anxious about falling behind. They admitted that intense academic pressure often led to poor mental health and decreased academic performance. In other words, academic stress appeared to be more debilitating than motivating, failing to inspire improvements or success. Adjusting to the international school system, particularly with classes conducted in English and advanced coursework, was a significant stressor. The high-achieving environment normalized heavy workloads and expectations, further increasing stress levels. While stress was common among participants, its negative impact on health and academics was more pronounced in students on rigorous academic tracks. Older students faced stronger negative consequences when dealing with college admissions pressures. The specific curriculum and academic environment of the international school significantly shaped the types and effects of the stressors experienced. New students, in particular, faced noticeable stress arising from difficulties adapting to a different educational system compared to their previous Korean school experience.

Key sources of academic stress included heavy workloads, class attendance, exams, peer rivalry, curriculum content, and a lack of adequate learning materials and subject-specific projects. High expectations from teachers and parents also contributed significantly to stress. Financial issues and concerns about future college prospects were additional major

stress factors. Participants reported severe stress related to personal expectations, external pressures, and the competitive academic environment, especially around tasks, rankings, and college admissions. Stress during exams was notably intense, peaking during preparation and exam periods. Feelings of anxiety, slow but careful work, procrastination, depression from past failures, rushing through tasks incorrectly, and helplessness were common emotional responses. Physiological symptoms like muscle tension and stomach discomfort were also mentioned.

Interpersonal stressors were frequently reported as well. Participants experienced conflicts with parents and family disagreements, as well as issues with teachers and peers, including bullying. Parental demands and teachers' expectations heightened stress during exams or when college decisions were pending. Participants expressed anxiety about disappointing their parents, especially when their sacrifices seemed unrecognized. Broader personal challenges, such as starting serious dating relationships during high school—an important period of developing independence—also contributed to stress. Many students struggled with trust issues, infidelity, insecurity, and emotional abuse within these relationships. The transition from middle to high school was a vulnerable period, requiring students to handle new academic, financial, and social responsibilities and build relationships with peers and teachers.

Newcomers to the international school system faced significant cultural and linguistic challenges in adapting to a new educational setting. This often led to self-doubt about their identities. During puberty and adolescence, students were navigating their sense of self amid a multilingual environment, which added to their stress. The school environment itself was a major stressor. Students went through an acclimatization period, experiencing culture shocks at various levels. Changes in policies and news, especially in the U.S., caused additional worries about their future. Physical stressors included poor study postures and sitting improperly in crowded classrooms, which caused muscle strain.

International schools in Korea have become increasingly popular among Korean students in recent years. Jeju stands out as a leading destination, hosting a specialized international school established through public policy. Recently, these schools have shifted their focus from expanding in scale to enhancing the quality of education. Despite this trend, there is a lack of academic research on the factors that influence international students' stress levels and their cultural and academic adjustment. Most existing studies rely on quantitative data and do not offer detailed insights into the students' inner thoughts and emotions. The strategic vision, mission, curriculum, and activities of international schools significantly affect students' adaptation both culturally and academically. On an individual level, a student's

ability to adapt is influenced by personal awareness and traits, such as motivation to learn, academic self-confidence, learning strategies, English language skills, and overall learning ability. Additionally, effective communication within the school—such as positive relationships between teachers and students, friendly peer interactions, and a supportive classroom environment—are crucial for helping international students adapt swiftly to the academic demands and the school system.

With the recent increase in school bullying and adolescent mental health challenges, adapting to school life has become a contentious issue. Without insight into students' school experiences and stress factors, finding solutions and coping strategies is challenging. Additionally, adolescents' approaches to problem-solving differ significantly, requiring more research. Therefore, understanding how students cope and respond in the context of international schools in their home country is essential for creating more effective educational policies for youth. The study suggests that developing programs to assist international school students in higher grades with school adjustment and positive stress management is important.

This study examined the stressors experienced by high school students in the Jeju international school district. Using a semi-structured survey, researchers collected narratives that revealed recurring themes and subcategories of stress, offering valuable insights for international schools in Korea. The inductive coding framework not only categorized these stressors but also provides a potential reference for students facing similar challenges.

However, this study has several limitations. First, its focus was restricted to the Jeju educational district. Second, the chosen survey tool limited the diversity and depth of responses. Some participants appeared to answer hastily, and a few responses were not directly relevant to the research topic. For future studies, a larger sample size is recommended to gather more comprehensive data. Researchers may also consider conducting interviews with more targeted questions to better capture the lived experiences of international school students regarding stress.

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